



## **Arkansas Game and Fish Commission Aerial Waterfowl Survey Report**

### **January 19-23, 2026**

Arkansas Game and Fish Commission Wildlife Management Division employees Tristan Bulice, William Guy, Brett Leach, and Derek Furr conducted the late-January aerial survey in the Mississippi Alluvial Valley (Delta), Arkansas River Valley, and southwest Arkansas. Due to the major winter storm, observers completed as much of the survey as possible before the storm hit; however, were unable to fly the Little River Ditches survey zone. Biologists conducting transect-based surveys in the Delta estimated 337,479 mallards and 694,286 total ducks (Table 1), while duck population estimates in the Arkansas River Valley totaled 25,542 ducks, including 12,075 mallards (Table 2). Staff performing cruise surveys in southwest Arkansas reported an estimated 19,365 ducks, with 8,030 of those being mallards (Table 2). Arctic goose population estimates totaled 1,478,989 light (lesser snow and Ross's) geese and 246,472 greater white-fronted geese in the Delta.

The Delta mallard population estimate was 121,205 mallards below the 2025 late-January estimate and 343,221 mallards below the 2010-2025 late-January long-term average. Total duck population estimates were 99,456 birds below the 2025 late-January estimates and 503,937 birds below the long-term (Figure 1). Mallards typically account for about 55 percent of all ducks in the Delta during the late-January survey; however, this survey period mallards made up 49 percent of the total duck estimate. Most notably, biologists estimated more than 50,000 mallards in 4 survey zones: Bayou Meto-Lower Arkansas, Black-Upper White, L' Anguille, and the Lower St. Francis. Total duck estimates were greatest in these survey zones and Big Creek additionally accounted for a just over 90,000 total ducks. Hotspot maps indicate several key duck concentration areas in the northern half of the Delta and fairly evenly distributed throughout the central portion of the Delta (Figures 3 and 4).

In the Arkansas River Valley, mallard estimates were 68 percent below the late-January long-term average, while total duck estimates were 54 percent below the long-term average (Figure 2). During the late-January survey, mallards made up 47 percent of the total duck estimate, 14 percent lower than the long-term average. Most of the mallards (67 percent) were estimated in the Point Remove-Plumerville survey zone. Total duck estimates were also highest in this survey zone, which accounted for 72 percent of the total ducks estimated. Hotspot maps highlight key concentration areas primarily in the Point Remove-Plumerville survey zone (Figures 5 and 6). Duck numbers in southwest Arkansas saw an uptick in bird numbers this survey period compared to the previous surveys this year. Mallard counts were 4% below the late-January long-term average, while total duck populations were 21 percent below average. Of the mallards recorded, the majority (75 percent) were concentrated along the Red River between U.S. Highway 82 and the Sulphur River.

This duck season was characterized by dry conditions, ranking from the 3<sup>rd</sup> driest on record in northeast Arkansas to the 22<sup>nd</sup> driest in southeast portion of the state (Figure 7). January has continued to see dry conditions and have been classified as in even further drought with 99 percent of the state in moderate to exceptional drought (Figure 8). This was the last waterfowl survey of the 2025-26 wintering period.

Table 1. Waterfowl abundance estimates in Arkansas during the late November (Nov), mid-December (Dec), early-January Midwinter Survey (MWS) and late-January (Jan) aerial waterfowl survey periods, 2009-2026, in the Mississippi Alluvial Valley (MAV) using stratified random sampling of transects.

|               |        |             | Survey Zone                     |             |                             |           |                     |         |             |                             |                      |                   |             | MAV Total |
|---------------|--------|-------------|---------------------------------|-------------|-----------------------------|-----------|---------------------|---------|-------------|-----------------------------|----------------------|-------------------|-------------|-----------|
|               |        |             | Bayou Bartholomew - Bayou Boeuf | Bayou Macon | Bayou Meto - Lower Arkansas | Big Creek | Black - Upper White | Cache   | L' Anguille | Lower White - Bayou Des Arc | Little River Ditches | Lower St. Francis | Lower White |           |
| Survey Period | Nov-09 | Mallards    |                                 |             |                             |           |                     |         |             |                             |                      |                   |             | 124,065   |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                                 |             |                             |           |                     |         |             |                             |                      |                   |             | 794,405   |
|               | Dec-09 | Mallards    |                                 |             |                             |           |                     |         |             |                             |                      |                   |             | 648,955   |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                                 |             |                             |           |                     |         |             |                             |                      |                   |             | 2,046,969 |
|               | MWS-10 | Mallards    |                                 |             |                             |           |                     |         |             |                             |                      |                   |             | 2,309,453 |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                                 |             |                             |           |                     |         |             |                             |                      |                   |             | 2,887,810 |
|               | Jan-10 | Mallards    |                                 |             |                             |           |                     |         |             |                             |                      |                   |             | 2,063,243 |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                                 |             |                             |           |                     |         |             |                             |                      |                   |             | 3,153,410 |
|               | Nov-10 | Mallards    |                                 |             |                             |           |                     |         |             |                             |                      |                   |             | 180,198   |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                                 |             |                             |           |                     |         |             |                             |                      |                   |             | 1,133,126 |
|               | Dec-10 | Mallards    |                                 |             |                             |           |                     |         |             |                             |                      |                   |             | 1,247,697 |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                                 |             |                             |           |                     |         |             |                             |                      |                   |             | 1,860,894 |
|               | MWS-11 | Mallards    |                                 |             |                             |           |                     |         |             |                             |                      |                   |             | 671,982   |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                                 |             |                             |           |                     |         |             |                             |                      |                   |             | 1,192,518 |
|               | Jan-11 | Mallards    |                                 |             |                             |           |                     |         |             |                             |                      |                   |             | 1,311,245 |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                                 |             |                             |           |                     |         |             |                             |                      |                   |             | 1,786,677 |
|               | Nov-11 | Mallards    | 4,750                           | -           | 15,717                      | 66        | 9,968               | 47,902  | 7,577       | 10,896                      | 2,432                | 36                | 32,736      | 132,080   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 52,662                          | 19,346      | 174,725                     | 1,367     | 32,914              | 77,686  | 36,010      | 78,700                      | 40,038               | 61                | 114,332     | 627,841   |
|               | Dec-11 | Mallards    | 39,569                          | 2,136       | 90,328                      | 10,161    | 73,576              | 226,861 | 48,173      | 206,485                     | 367,290              | 122,032           | 283,418     | 1,470,029 |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 135,903                         | 14,267      | 298,196                     | 32,799    | 171,366             | 306,191 | 94,423      | 360,232                     | 417,990              | 247,685           | 339,894     | 2,418,946 |
|               | MWS-12 | Mallards    | 7,956                           | 989         | 110,141                     | 87,360    | 35,244              | 318,991 | 51,493      | 43,618                      | 51,721               | 8,604             | 37,862      | 753,979   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 29,124                          | 2,318       | 161,830                     | 161,081   | 51,447              | 368,370 | 89,139      | 60,802                      | 75,241               | 51,660            | 65,861      | 1,116,873 |
|               | Jan-12 | Mallards    | 22,365                          | 5,917       | 48,569                      | 82,272    | 47,069              | 102,400 | 38,682      | 232,214                     | 80,546               | 11,193            | 82,291      | 753,518   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 47,985                          | 17,165      | 87,045                      | 114,331   | 128,018             | 162,763 | 105,318     | 321,724                     | 86,482               | 70,673            | 122,334     | 1,263,838 |
|               | Nov-12 | Mallards    | 2,543                           | 7,176       | 44,732                      | 5,298     | 50,797              | 112,327 | 97,712      | 14,306                      | 19,136               | 36,967            | 51,127      | 442,121   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 11,037                          | 38,220      | 95,784                      | 34,352    | 79,726              | 171,744 | 164,874     | 68,621                      | 25,852               | 66,825            | 75,764      | 832,799   |
|               | Dec-12 | Mallards    | 37,887                          | 11,126      | 40,660                      | 4,525     | 157,624             | 54,417  | 45,467      | 8,517                       | 29,542               | 8,993             | 17,448      | 416,206   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 121,538                         | 22,648      | 70,813                      | 18,267    | 233,838             | 81,262  | 95,628      | 30,981                      | 35,021               | 45,649            | 31,270      | 786,915   |
|               | MWS-13 | Mallards    | 30,438                          | 12,508      | 75,690                      | 16,112    | 48,272              | 57,409  | 32,133      | 20,437                      | 48,267               | 4,633             | 105,865     | 451,764   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 54,951                          | 19,145      | 120,222                     | 22,876    | 60,929              | 84,871  | 68,389      | 27,503                      | 56,231               | 7,511             | 142,842     | 665,470   |
|               | Jan-13 | Mallards    | 28,836                          | 8,921       | 90,090                      | 36,204    | 93,035              | 62,369  | 26,058      | 7,344                       | 3,511                | 93,337            | 27,036      | 476,741   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 128,058                         | 48,672      | 127,548                     | 48,364    | 138,314             | 103,878 | 52,116      | 9,588                       | 3,665                | 145,229           | 32,483      | 837,915   |
|               | Nov-13 | Mallards    | 13,582                          | 2,841       | 24,371                      | 2,900     | 25,948              | 66,501  | 54,163      | -                           | 13,242               | 1,445             | 39,840      | 244,833   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 200,157                         | 38,409      | 107,960                     | 18,100    | 148,225             | 111,257 | 99,517      | 49,598                      | 46,545               | 4,206             | 114,572     | 938,546   |
|               | Dec-13 | Mallards    | 73,158                          | 20,062      | 71,142                      | 7,904     | 72,485              | 25,429  | 63,845      | 54,023                      | 37,107               | 27,422            | 22,806      | 475,383   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 154,707                         | 31,980      | 145,453                     | 26,009    | 98,951              | 36,088  | 122,202     | 77,353                      | 47,533               | 33,835            | 60,612      | 834,723   |
|               | MWS-14 | Mallards    | 104,455                         | 33,520      | 164,150                     | 3,070     | 66,080              | 216,061 | 934         | 56,508                      | 25,124               | 13,835            | 123,399     | 807,136   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 114,764                         | 44,313      | 182,263                     | 3,070     | 75,082              | 247,069 | 1,196       | 80,835                      | 25,124               | 17,143            | 136,817     | 927,676   |
|               | Nov-14 | Mallards    | 9,409                           | 17,100      | 136,741                     | 22,901    | 34,196              | 19,077  | 3,454       | 22,216                      | 128,948              | 69,511            | 84,007      | 547,560   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 83,914                          | 51,660      | 234,759                     | 80,425    | 70,814              | 29,520  | 12,382      | 45,023                      | 171,835              | 80,469            | 132,448     | 993,249   |
|               | Dec-14 | Mallards    | 81,653                          | 48,048      | 53,377                      | 7,836     | 159,637             | 12,105  | 36,370      | 8,308                       | 23,966               | 16,198            | 172,746     | 620,244   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 107,261                         | 50,700      | 168,894                     | 12,430    | 212,520             | 18,005  | 72,920      | 15,300                      | 24,196               | 46,082            | 251,119     | 979,427   |
|               | MWS-15 | Mallards    | 113,960                         | 29,818      | 162,687                     | 99,270    | 110,723             | 25,064  | 31,083      | 10,033                      | 8,855                | 162,042           | 172,026     | 925,561   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 130,296                         | 30,988      | 188,203                     | 106,124   | 148,309             | 39,287  | 55,675      | 18,601                      | 8,855                | 321,514           | 180,142     | 1,227,994 |
|               | Nov-15 | Mallards    | 3,599                           | 43,200      | 17,915                      | 19,253    | 15,382              | 46,418  | 7,625       | 15,597                      | 9,093                | 40,889            | 42,941      | 261,912   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 203,640                         | 120,492     | 126,942                     | 25,333    | 49,581              | 149,017 | 18,051      | 22,088                      | 14,459               | 43,547            | 116,041     | 889,191   |
|               | Dec-15 | Mallards    | 6,103                           | 1,287       | 59,153                      | 17,784    | 107,474             | 109,493 | 13,682      | 5,814                       | 11,408               | 9,242             | 5,837       | 347,277   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 98,739                          | 25,214      | 106,887                     | 100,928   | 223,106             | 221,060 | 65,282      | 40,127                      | 21,975               | 28,436            | 16,697      | 948,451   |
|               | MWS-16 | Mallards    | 31,506                          | 13,806      | 84,035                      | 14,558    | 53,900              | 97,829  | 106,172     | 20,482                      | 60,454               | -                 | 170,364     | 653,106   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 55,172                          | 32,204      | 125,780                     | 37,662    | 91,665              | 164,831 | 155,016     | 28,744                      | 74,250               | 3,943             | 226,832     | 996,099   |
|               | Jan-16 | Mallards    | 22,606                          | 9,068       | 59,169                      | 22,800    | 80,590              | 135,110 | -           | 116,169                     | -                    | 74,942            | 96,330      | 616,784   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 94,269                          | 21,294      | 75,702                      | 33,212    | 105,643             | 184,233 | -           | 291,312                     | -                    | 74,942            | 111,648     | 992,255   |
|               | Nov-16 | Mallards    | 0                               | 0           | 26,781                      | 21,094    | 0                   | 1,792   | 3,007       | 285                         | 16,572               | 0                 | 12,381      | 81,912    |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 5,983                           | 17,179      | 71,612                      | 57,213    | 1,167               | 24,772  | 29,140      | 1,064                       | 33,788               | 9,724             | 17,919      | 269,561   |
|               | Dec-16 | Mallards    | 15,104                          | 475         | 150,591                     | 31,456    | 23,246              | 91,324  | 19,088      | 8,160                       | 20,241               | 20,767            | 64,914      | 445,364   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 72,010                          | 8,361       | 207,710                     | 43,213    | 26,332              | 115,977 | 30,448      | 43,642                      | 30,147               | 86,977            | 85,357      | 750,174   |
|               | MWS-17 | Mallards    | 72,405                          | 40,448      | 219,106                     | 22,908    | 14,102              | 128,174 | 20,651      | 12,460                      | 8,873                | 41,202            | 70,677      | 651,004   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 95,012                          | 57,394      | 250,439                     | 26,358    | 38,389              | 236,142 | 36,784      | 13,479                      | 9,892                | 75,996            | 75,677      | 915,562   |
|               | Jan-17 | Mallards    | 7,154                           | 15,135      | 146,710                     | 20,187    | 41,860              | 159,212 | 47,507      | 19,013                      | 8,116                | 31,646            | 63,039      | 559,579   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 73,706                          | 66,649      | 225,301                     | 28,396    | 87,546              | 277,917 | 85,046      | 57,463                      | 10,021               | 51,226            | 91,663      | 1,054,934 |

Table 1, continued. Waterfowl abundance estimates in Arkansas during the late November (Nov), mid-December (Dec), early-January Midwinter Survey (MWS) and late-January (Jan) aerial waterfowl survey periods, 2009-2026, in the Mississippi Alluvial Valley (MAV) using stratified random sampling of transects.

|               |        |             | Survey Zone    |             |              |           |               |         |             |               |              |                   |             |           |
|---------------|--------|-------------|----------------|-------------|--------------|-----------|---------------|---------|-------------|---------------|--------------|-------------------|-------------|-----------|
|               |        |             | Bayou Bartholo | Bayou Macon | Bayou Meto - | Big Creek | Black - Upper | Cache   | L' Anguille | Lower White - | Little River | Lower St. Francis | Lower White | MAV Total |
| Survey Period | Dec-17 | Mallards    | 4,921          | 3,151       | 116,026      | 19,729    | 84,718        | 38,466  | 26,874      | 2,400         | 26,662       | 100,522           | 9,508       | 432,977   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 28,720         | 12,448      | 192,672      | 24,770    | 158,347       | 70,974  | 64,906      | 39,102        | 37,663       | 139,882           | 21,915      | 791,399   |
|               | MWS-18 | Mallards    | 2,458          | 34,577      | 390,205      | 92,504    | 40,402        | 132,049 | 35,330      | 1,402         | 12,274       | 54,505            | 153,625     | 949,331   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 3,027          | 62,533      | 415,037      | 110,084   | 44,660        | 140,405 | 58,871      | 3,845         | 13,969       | 122,781           | 180,326     | 1,155,538 |
|               | Jan-18 | Mallards    | 3,276          | 10,690      | 104,937      | 116,012   | 8,117         | 21,688  | 11,050      | 555           | 36           | 70,030            | 63,378      | 409,769   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 42,652         | 35,963      | 118,023      | 116,275   | 10,768        | 22,626  | 17,671      | 2,313         | 39           | 143,833           | 69,635      | 579,794   |
|               | Nov-18 | Mallards    | 251            | 476         | 66,867       | 7,222     | 91,284        | 110,677 | 43,214      | 1,572         | 40,305       | -                 | 2,226       | 364,094   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 57,431         | 17,075      | 131,319      | 11,649    | 214,432       | 265,268 | 73,438      | 3,900         | 57,849       | 2,040             | 2,997       | 837,398   |
|               | Dec-18 | Mallards    | 2,770          | 7,210       | 118,723      | 124,685   | 33,242        | 145,660 | 84,416      | 9,825         | 31,723       | 45,074            | 83,800      | 687,126   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 37,533         | 59,037      | 202,869      | 147,520   | 48,481        | 185,811 | 236,571     | 18,709        | 43,519       | 110,004           | 91,944      | 1,181,998 |
|               | MWS-19 | Mallards    | 50,569         | 7,541       | 80,381       | 22,208    | 81,122        | 85,902  | 38,201      | 16,263        | 13,588       | 119,119           | 40,885      | 555,779   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 123,101        | 28,889      | 127,772      | 28,331    | 168,597       | 137,596 | 76,985      | 24,204        | 50,781       | 211,288           | 77,009      | 1,054,553 |
|               | Jan-19 | Mallards    | 3,592          | 12,942      | 91,603       | 21,192    | 53,730        | 132,098 | 49,299      | 19,298        | 3,937        | 50,190            | 117,601     | 555,481   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 35,277         | 48,923      | 125,488      | 65,460    | 94,400        | 247,074 | 99,281      | 45,922        | 4,810        | 63,203            | 134,519     | 964,356   |
|               | Nov-19 | Mallards    | 4,095          | 2,656       | 18,897       | 10,217    | 12,387        | 102,483 | 28,188      | 8,764         | 40,098       | 1,068             | 13,419      | 242,272   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 27,470         | 33,184      | 56,514       | 16,489    | 47,286        | 198,832 | 102,188     | 28,529        | 52,422       | 90,384            | 28,433      | 681,730   |
|               | Dec-19 | Mallards    | 3,141          | 1,410       | 60,346       | 24,176    | 73,688        | 103,543 | 19,682      | 9,443         | 70,195       | 60,545            | 20,914      | 447,083   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 52,686         | 10,283      | 129,781      | 28,373    | 166,850       | 185,574 | 49,036      | 39,966        | 74,342       | 124,603           | 37,162      | 898,656   |
|               | MWS-20 | Mallards    | 40,730         | 7,032       | 49,576       | 10,209    | 56,228        | 76,464  | 57,146      | 40,810        | 11,322       | 333,707           | 46,736      | 729,960   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 179,674        | 26,737      | 94,990       | 35,729    | 95,958        | 133,810 | 148,207     | 54,851        | 12,291       | 611,108           | 78,730      | 1,472,083 |
|               | Jan-20 | Mallards    | 4,225          | 7,189       | 96,105       | 26,071    | 130,185       | 47,918  | 28,615      | 3,329         | 26,127       | 116,120           | 61,002      | 546,885   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 45,122         | 65,224      | 198,473      | 41,544    | 215,178       | 75,474  | 75,084      | 18,046        | 34,296       | 190,198           | 85,771      | 1,044,410 |
|               | Dec-20 | Mallards    | 17,899         | 86,795      | 13,611       | 8,565     | 3,869         | 38,361  | 20,225      | 9,044         | 7,128        | 36,802            | 12,753      | 255,052   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 57,991         | 169,264     | 46,643       | 23,418    | 18,710        | 83,276  | 43,232      | 14,636        | 33,444       | 85,922            | 56,441      | 632,977   |
|               | MWS-21 | Mallards    | 36,123         | 37,667      | 93,865       | 10,850    | 63,320        | 42,077  | 3,288       | 2,028         | 70,340       | 31,220            | 67,535      | 458,314   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 62,282         | 57,556      | 212,836      | 25,105    | 128,287       | 149,534 | 11,855      | 5,967         | 122,325      | 92,015            | 210,449     | 1,078,209 |
|               | Jan-21 | Mallards    | 8,591          | 24,694      | 82,346       | 11,291    | 23,970        | 53,046  | 38,576      | 15,881        | 18,335       | 94,037            | 157,153     | 527,920   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 30,437         | 75,822      | 242,914      | 41,630    | 37,284        | 146,785 | 108,042     | 30,232        | 44,659       | 178,998           | 271,348     | 1,208,147 |
|               | Dec-21 | Mallards    | 6,097          | 3,141       | 38,795       | 1,977     | 24,843        | 85,582  | 13,647      | 1,544         | 12,401       | 40,941            | 97,096      | 326,064   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 25,141         | 9,219       | 79,722       | 7,929     | 54,457        | 144,733 | 18,237      | 14,368        | 30,937       | 74,452            | 107,261     | 566,456   |
|               | MWS-22 | Mallards    | 10,039         | 1,057       | 183,508      | 65,005    | 42,562        | 68,052  | 23,354      | 2,822         | 32,116       | 126,836           | 62,108      | 617,459   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 24,915         | 12,150      | 250,319      | 83,273    | 61,194        | 112,421 | 49,531      | 4,840         | 50,867       | 235,345           | 76,392      | 961,247   |
|               | Jan-22 | Mallards    | 5,121          | 343         | 83,615       | 2,614     | 57,109        | 160,243 | 21,108      | 1,451         | 2,826        | 166,793           | 33,582      | 534,805   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 34,854         | 6,460       | 164,504      | 59,899    | 84,993        | 294,227 | 41,824      | 13,641        | 21,507       | 363,615           | 50,664      | 1,136,188 |
|               | Dec-22 | Mallards    | 152            | 4,939       | 142,175      | 28,742    | 125,216       | 100,868 | 1,554       | 350           | 4,714        | 0                 | 72,136      | 480,846   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 58,814         | 22,576      | 277,775      | 63,965    | 252,647       | 292,466 | 23,972      | 3,729         | 12,228       | 6,592             | 121,794     | 1,136,558 |
|               | MWS-23 | Mallards    | 11,293         | 927         | 184,745      | 28,256    | 153,403       | 156,118 | 40,216      | 754           | 6,135        | 251,624           | 95,779      | 929,250   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 30,802         | 5,001       | 315,930      | 148,965   | 307,897       | 335,576 | 61,243      | 3,240         | 6,343        | 395,136           | 133,190     | 1,743,323 |
|               | Jan-23 | Mallards    | 1,097          | -           | 79,191       | 44,423    | 44,186        | 118,216 | 55,138      | 4,307         | 22,975       | 67,739            | 27,469      | 464,741   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 57,928         | 25,946      | 232,139      | 91,424    | 75,572        | 331,600 | 103,483     | 87,378        | 29,545       | 121,397           | 50,758      | 1,207,170 |
|               | Dec-23 | Mallards    | 0              | 0           | 13,033       | 0         | 15,074        | 20,234  | 20,207      | 0             | 5,627        | 609               | 4,581       | 79,365    |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 33,663         | 26,195      | 99,680       | 9,537     | 15,137        | 146,787 | 34,189      | 17,924        | 5,817        | 1,450             | 59,481      | 449,860   |
|               | MWS-24 | Mallards    | 12,690         | 6,845       | 50,111       | 23,986    | 43,621        | 63,481  | 23,407      | 6,341         | 3,067        | 15,640            | 20,506      | 269,695   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 37,396         | 21,002      | 90,717       | 43,046    | 169,153       | 180,783 | 66,856      | 16,796        | 3,067        | 20,759            | 32,516      | 682,091   |
|               | Jan-24 | Mallards    | 0              | 1,560       | 38,634       | 11,425    | 75,354        | 49,799  | 5,483       | 0             | 22,816       | 4,223             | 41,107      | 250,401   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 36,223         | 3,151       | 119,259      | 25,865    | 170,842       | 141,623 | 36,120      | 14,096        | 37,389       | 4,744             | 162,980     | 752,292   |
|               | Dec-24 | Mallards    | 28,474         | 7,185       | 14,414       | 10,539    | 24,544        | 19,307  | 5,124       | 11,424        | 0            | 19,159            | 13,253      | 153,423   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 81,721         | 24,611      | 51,021       | 13,849    | 59,256        | 173,571 | 25,155      | 39,134        | 245          | 33,822            | 27,592      | 529,977   |
|               | MWS-25 | Mallards    | 13,712         | 13,280      | 69,102       | 15,909    | 101,937       | 121,523 | 25,619      | 18,074        | 4,048        | 31,448            | 37,366      | 452,018   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 42,272         | 28,285      | 168,977      | 36,142    | 147,100       | 233,888 | 78,441      | 33,497        | 6,394        | 77,753            | 71,797      | 924,546   |
|               | Jan-25 | Mallards    | 20,637         | 6,260       | 98,640       | 52,761    | 19,999        | 59,928  | 17,836      | 60,792        | 26,987       | 2,844             | 92,000      | 458,684   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 54,089         | 13,689      | 167,148      | 91,774    | 25,044        | 114,956 | 38,924      | 134,603       | 36,187       | 23,105            | 94,223      | 793,742   |
|               | Dec-25 | Mallards    | 12,816         | 5,661       | 54,702       | 131,936   | 24,699        | 127,545 | 78,690      | 15,242        | 3,987        | 6,517             | 36,369      | 498,164   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 58,482         | 11,388      | 159,138      | 429,157   | 106,953       | 277,910 | 235,765     | 25,529        | 3,987        | 80,372            | 69,673      | 1,458,354 |
|               | MWS-26 | Mallards    | 15,796         | 25,834      | 142,659      | 8,968     | 36,344        | 33,199  | 20,015      | 1,899         | 2,637        | 8,863             | 37,897      | 334,110   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 35,347         | 46,582      | 174,950      | 30,324    | 96,819        | 61,113  | 24,881      | 5,571         | 4,477        | 9,775             | 54,866      | 544,705   |
|               | Jan-26 | Mallards    | 10,489         | 4,074       | 54,054       | 17,092    | 63,639        | 30,234  | 56,535      | 12,587        | -            | 74,095            | 14,681      | 337,479   |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 40,889         | 7,956       | 138,528      | 90,052    | 81,888        | 54,407  | 69,844      | 28,866        | -            | 132,745           | 49,111      | 694,286   |

Table 2. Waterfowl abundance estimates in western Arkansas during the late November (Nov), mid-December (Dec), early-January Midwinter Survey (MWS) and late-January (Jan) aerial waterfowl survey periods, 2009-2026. Beginning in Jan. 2013, surveys in the Arkansas River Valley (ARV) were conducted using stratified random sampling of transects, while past ARV surveys and surveys in southwest Arkansas were conducted using “cruise” surveys.

|               |        |             | Survey Zone           |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           |         | Arkansas River Valley Total | Southwest Arkansas Total |
|---------------|--------|-------------|-----------------------|--------|---------------------------|-----------------|------------|------------|------------|------------------------|---------------------------|---------|-----------------------------|--------------------------|
|               |        |             | Bigelow - Lake Conway | Cadron | East Dardanelle Reservoir | Fourche La Fave | Frog Bayou | Holla Bend | Petit Jean | Pt. Remove Plumerville | West Dardanelle Reservoir |         |                             |                          |
| Survey Period | Nov-09 | Mallards    |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 13,731  | 5,480                       |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 31,416  | 19,140                      |                          |
|               | Dec-09 | Mallards    |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 18,580  | 19,230                      |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 31,304  | 31,820                      |                          |
|               | MWS-10 | Mallards    |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 58,815  | 34,590                      |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 81,685  | 36,060                      |                          |
|               | Jan-10 | Mallards    |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 14,359  | 19,840                      |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 20,336  | 27,705                      |                          |
|               | Nov-10 | Mallards    |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 96      | 14,010                      |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 5,966   | 30,300                      |                          |
|               | Dec-10 | Mallards    |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 25,064  | 2,390                       |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 28,054  | 21,106                      |                          |
|               | MWS-11 | Mallards    |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 26,318  | 15,027                      |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 40,470  | 21,267                      |                          |
|               | Jan-11 | Mallards    |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 41,850  | -                           |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 60,635  | -                           |                          |
|               | Nov-11 | Mallards    |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 12,225  | -                           |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 19,870  | -                           |                          |
|               | Dec-11 | Mallards    |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 21,389  | -                           |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 40,919  | -                           |                          |
|               | MWS-12 | Mallards    |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 7,264   | -                           |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 13,339  | -                           |                          |
|               | Jan-12 | Mallards    |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 13,900  | -                           |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 21,000  | -                           |                          |
|               | Nov-12 | Mallards    |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 1,182   | 13,090                      |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 7,732   | 21,935                      |                          |
|               | Dec-12 | Mallards    |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 13,975  | 10,245                      |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 22,417  | 17,105                      |                          |
|               | MWS-13 | Mallards    |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 16,893  | 8,165                       |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks |                       |        |                           |                 |            |            |            |                        |                           | 26,058  | 14,630                      |                          |
|               | Jan-13 | Mallards    | -                     | 408    | 10,000                    | 372             | 1,837      | 630        | 627        | 1,843                  | 917                       | 16,634  | -                           |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                     | 1,428  | 10,180                    | 372             | 1,971      | 990        | 902        | 3,687                  | 7,857                     | 28,011  | -                           |                          |
|               | Nov-13 | Mallards    | 240                   | 187    | 4,660                     | 800             | 0          | 144        | 0          | 754                    | 253                       | 7,038   | 4,455                       |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 320                   | 187    | 14,320                    | 1,920           | 0          | 1,080      | 528        | 965                    | 3,307                     | 22,627  | 19,145                      |                          |
|               | Dec-13 | Mallards    | 576                   | 245    | 5,472                     | 1,728           | 358        | 162        | 1,320      | 3,429                  | 2,176                     | 15,466  | 10,130                      |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 1,604                 | 2,713  | 8,672                     | 1,728           | 1,836      | 3,132      | 1,501      | 4,329                  | 3,941                     | 29,456  | 29,070                      |                          |
|               | MWS-14 | Mallards    | 11,767                | 816    | 2,898                     | 4,800           | -          | 2,160      | 715        | 13,703                 | 3,449                     | 40,306  | 18,385                      |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 14,441                | 816    | 8,711                     | 5,124           | -          | 2,934      | 957        | 22,177                 | 6,087                     | 61,247  | 35,875                      |                          |
|               | Nov-14 | Mallards    | 926                   | 7,140  | 12,114                    | 704             | 924        | 4,518      | 10,428     | 7,125                  | 392                       | 44,271  | 15,890                      |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 5,040                 | 10,540 | 45,485                    | 4,256           | 3,248      | 4,518      | 19,932     | 12,039                 | 624                       | 105,682 | 29,790                      |                          |
|               | Dec-14 | Mallards    | 720                   | 224    | 1,028                     | 640             | 373        | 3,006      | 2,541      | 1,343                  | 299                       | 10,174  | 21,200                      |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 1,242                 | 530    | 33,805                    | 1,296           | 373        | 4,194      | 4,059      | 6,991                  | 299                       | 52,789  | 29,400                      |                          |
|               | MWS-15 | Mallards    | 3,929                 | 143    | 5,813                     | 221             | -          | 11,138     | 0          | 2,107                  | 3,531                     | 26,882  | 19,245                      |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 10,594                | 755    | 18,649                    | 221             | -          | 13,455     | 224        | 2,107                  | 9,871                     | 55,876  | 28,695                      |                          |
|               | Nov-15 | Mallards    | 270                   | -      | 1,867                     | -               | 149        | 2,430      | 561        | 4,785                  | 64                        | 10,126  | 21,580                      |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 270                   | 449    | 2,898                     | -               | 1,170      | 14,760     | 726        | 7,042                  | 64                        | 27,379  | 37,060                      |                          |
|               | Dec-15 | Mallards    | 1,440                 | 340    | 320                       | 160             | 140        | 563        | 165        | 2,864                  | 1,027                     | 7,019   | 11,425                      |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 4,140                 | 374    | 3,140                     | 992             | 140        | 7,088      | 165        | 6,913                  | 3,274                     | 26,226  | 17,950                      |                          |
|               | MWS-16 | Mallards    | 411                   | 775    | 352                       | 496             | 14,000     | 3,042      | 726        | 2,544                  | 6,070                     | 28,416  | 10,310                      |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 617                   | 775    | 6,752                     | 896             | 17,562     | 6,102      | 990        | 3,808                  | 15,019                    | 52,521  | 16,715                      |                          |
|               | Jan-16 | Mallards    | 634                   | 918    | 2,743                     | 576             | 373        | 1,548      | 14,388     | 8,479                  | 4,622                     | 34,281  | 14,735                      |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 634                   | 918    | 3,817                     | 1,536           | 1,966      | 2,088      | 18,777     | 11,815                 | 5,478                     | 47,029  | 19,565                      |                          |
|               | Nov-16 | Mallards    | -                     | -      | 818                       | -               | 0          | -          | -          | -                      | 99                        | 917     | 5,165                       |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                     | -      | 6,530                     | -               | 814        | -          | -          | -                      | 100                       | 7,444   | 14,690                      |                          |
|               | Dec-16 | Mallards    | 112                   | -      | -                         | 739             | 187        | 2,612      | 296        | 234                    | 8,186                     | 12,364  | 34,946                      |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 333                   | -      | 3,165                     | 1,016           | 988        | 3,248      | 550        | 1,788                  | 10,192                    | 21,278  | 39,360                      |                          |
|               | MWS-17 | Mallards    | 24                    | 1,538  | 180                       | 831             | 242        | 448        | 5,050      | 1,808                  | 2,333                     | 12,454  | 19,386                      |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 325                   | 2,137  | 453                       | 12,788          | 2,167      | 547        | 5,499      | 4,461                  | 14,900                    | 43,277  | 31,679                      |                          |
|               | Jan-17 | Mallards    | 17                    | 627    | 16,432                    | 3,812           | 1,019      | 5,394      | 1,561      | 14,818                 | 4,768                     | 48,448  | 13,682                      |                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 17                    | 1,647  | 17,810                    | 11,308          | 2,595      | 5,638      | 1,825      | 14,836                 | 4,917                     | 60,593  | 26,594                      |                          |

Table 2, continued. Waterfowl abundance estimates in western Arkansas during the late November (Nov), mid-December (Dec), early-January Midwinter Survey (MWS) and late-January (Jan) aerial waterfowl survey periods, 2009-2026. Beginning in Jan. 2013, surveys in the Arkansas River Valley (ARV) were conducted using stratified random sampling of transects, while past ARV surveys and surveys in southwest Arkansas were conducted using “cruise” surveys. The Bigelow-Lake Conway and Cadron strata were not flown beginning December, 2019.

|               |        |             | Survey Zone                 |        |                                 |                    |               |               |            |                           |                                 |                                   |                                |
|---------------|--------|-------------|-----------------------------|--------|---------------------------------|--------------------|---------------|---------------|------------|---------------------------|---------------------------------|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------|
|               |        |             | Bigelow -<br>Lake<br>Conway | Cadron | East<br>Dardanelle<br>Reservoir | Fourche<br>La Fave | Frog<br>Bayou | Holla<br>Bend | Petit Jean | Pt. Remove<br>Plumerville | West<br>Dardanelle<br>Reservoir | Arkansas<br>River Valley<br>Total | Southwest<br>Arkansas<br>Total |
| Survey Period | Dec-17 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 821                             | -                  | 0             | 1,184         | -          | -                         | 2,129                           | 4,134                             | 15,487                         |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 2,558                           | -                  | 2,972         | 3,654         | -          | -                         | 4,264                           | 13,448                            | 34,822                         |
|               | MWS-18 | Mallards    | 0                           | 0      | 10,862                          | 1,013              | 4,784         | 22,254        | 0          | 5,269                     | 6,711                           | 50,893                            | 18,412                         |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 510                         | 0      | 13,785                          | 2,114              | 5,880         | 36,695        | 0          | 13,843                    | 7,553                           | 80,380                            | 38,114                         |
|               | Jan-18 | Mallards    | 2,080                       | 3,144  | 11,881                          | 135                | 1,115         | 141,074       | 845        | 3,361                     | 5,214                           | 168,849                           | 10,849                         |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 3,420                       | 4,489  | 20,281                          | 227                | 3,826         | 174,542       | 3,150      | 3,313                     | 5,381                           | 218,629                           | 32,928                         |
|               | Nov-18 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 273                             | 2,956              | 3,617         | 198           | 4,733      | 7,074                     | 429                             | 19,280                            | 9,721                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 5,878                           | 3,319              | 3,895         | 253           | 8,867      | 9,956                     | 502                             | 32,670                            | 26,969                         |
|               | Dec-18 | Mallards    | 235                         | 326    | 2,440                           | 73                 | 179           | 3,292         | 462        | 7,426                     | 605                             | 15,038                            | 9,241                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 240                         | 330    | 4,483                           | 73                 | 630           | 3,472         | 1,771      | 10,920                    | 605                             | 22,514                            | 35,236                         |
|               | MWS-19 | Mallards    | 58                          | 382    | 841                             | 120                | 389           | 89            | 2,413      | 9,527                     | 4,418                           | 18,237                            | 3,507                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 58                          | 748    | 4,417                           | 192                | 2,446         | 100           | 3,875      | 23,206                    | 4,582                           | 39,620                            | 30,973                         |
|               | Jan-19 | Mallards    | 1,628                       | -      | 1,603                           | 169                | 728           | 607           | 2,234      | 1,928                     | 7,900                           | 16,797                            | 5,978                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 5,295                       | -      | 2,252                           | 2,762              | 869           | 785           | 2,381      | 2,488                     | 10,513                          | 27,347                            | 25,540                         |
|               | Nov-19 | Mallards    | 1,096                       | -      | 1,388                           | 243                | 4,235         | 550           | 592        | 744                       | 608                             | 9,456                             | 8,016                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | 1,081                       | -      | 2,067                           | 1,242              | 20,195        | 3,054         | 1,534      | 5,742                     | 1,754                           | 36,670                            | 17,193                         |
|               | Dec-19 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 461                             | 363                | 1,418         | 1,171         | 2,121      | 2,133                     | 3,377                           | 11,044                            | -                              |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 637                             | 672                | 1,595         | 2,286         | 3,146      | 4,160                     | 8,194                           | 20,691                            | -                              |
|               | MWS-20 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 7,995                           | 617                | 277           | 6,274         | 655        | 4,907                     | 196                             | 20,920                            | 2,237                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 10,702                          | 917                | 2,711         | 9,008         | 2,641      | 7,409                     | 959                             | 34,346                            | 26,955                         |
|               | Jan-20 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 561                             | 460                | 4,227         | 1,339         | 795        | 1,465                     | 4,153                           | 13,000                            | 1,960                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 4,792                           | 2,567              | 5,108         | 1,633         | 1,397      | 3,604                     | 6,254                           | 25,355                            | 18,480                         |
|               | Dec-20 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 1,452                           | 294                | 561           | 131           | 1,123      | 2,538                     | 1,313                           | 7,416                             | 12,367                         |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 4,606                           | 471                | 2,276         | 205           | 2,059      | 4,722                     | 2,616                           | 16,958                            | 45,832                         |
|               | MWS-21 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 0                               | 1,594              | 104           | 53            | 707        | 1,592                     | 5,315                           | 9,366                             | 4,597                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 1,647                           | 1,864              | 645           | 337           | 828        | 5,019                     | 11,017                          | 21,357                            | 9,104                          |
|               | Jan-21 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 729                             | 292                | 2,451         | 2,381         | 330        | 47,577                    | 1,383                           | 55,141                            | 5,846                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 1,741                           | 962                | 3,125         | 2,707         | 544        | 55,122                    | 5,212                           | 69,413                            | 49,122                         |
|               | Dec-21 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 1,422                           | 250                | 326           | 1,760         | 131        | 797                       | 2,033                           | 6,719                             | 10,019                         |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 6,058                           | 919                | 384           | 1,739         | 1,137      | 806                       | 2,391                           | 13,434                            | 54,031                         |
|               | MWS-22 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 2,252                           | 588                | 48            | 3,651         | 2,437      | 2,988                     | 686                             | 12,650                            | 4,597                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 4,348                           | 676                | 239           | 4,995         | 3,224      | 4,137                     | 1,034                           | 18,653                            | 9,104                          |
|               | Jan-22 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 1,373                           | 429                | 578           | 90            | 730        | 419                       | 1,650                           | 5,269                             | 2,838                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 5,213                           | 1,044              | 1,003         | 349           | 1,007      | 420                       | 2,188                           | 11,224                            | 10,078                         |
|               | Dec-22 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 0                               | 73                 | 383           | 1,436         | 159        | 4,537                     | 795                             | 7,383                             | 4,487                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 3,253                           | 279                | 1,856         | 3,217         | 1,498      | 11,006                    | 1,751                           | 22,860                            | 24,574                         |
|               | MWS-23 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 232                             | 457                | 178           | 4,508         | 2,932      | 17,636                    | -                               | 25,943                            | 6,180                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 828                             | 733                | 178           | 7,104         | 4,055      | 26,774                    | 1,336                           | 41,017                            | 14,283                         |
|               | Jan-23 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 385                             | 523                | 965           | 863           | 2,597      | 9,317                     | 881                             | 15,530                            | 3,746                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 650                             | 603                | 1,168         | 2,289         | 2,702      | 19,834                    | 1,697                           | 28,943                            | 19,174                         |
|               | Dec-23 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 2,445                           | 154                | 0             | 0             | 0          | 6,650                     | 584                             | 9,920                             | 4,517                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 3,627                           | 359                | 2,167         | 1             | 440        | 10,472                    | 584                             | 17,878                            | 35,857                         |
|               | MWS-24 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 497                             | 653                | 0             | 905           | 1,265      | 133                       | 389                             | 3,841                             | 2,980                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 4,292                           | 1,973              | 3,345         | 4,425         | 1,694      | 5,229                     | 389                             | 21,347                            | 28,200                         |
|               | Jan-24 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 6,977                           | 2,904              | 1,097         | 13,866        | 1,320      | 8,111                     | 4,047                           | 38,321                            | 5,455                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 16,253                          | 5,045              | 1,494         | 32,309        | 1,320      | 16,141                    | 4,202                           | 76,764                            | 22,830                         |
|               | Dec-24 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 2,484                           | 2,750              | 3,097         | 7,773         | 0          | 1,854                     | 1,167                           | 19,126                            | 3,305                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 3,919                           | 3,630              | 14,052        | 11,044        | 0          | 3,898                     | 4,358                           | 40,901                            | 17,960                         |
|               | MWS-25 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 2,147                           | 1,503              | 260           | 3,168         | 158        | 31,471                    | 350                             | 39,058                            | 2,660                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 4,692                           | 1,525              | 6,760         | 7,709         | 264        | 61,807                    | 1,362                           | 84,119                            | 22,160                         |
|               | Jan-25 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 4,539                           | 0                  | 496           | 0             | 53         | 389                       | 1,980                           | 7,456                             | 10,205                         |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 13,509                          | 0                  | 1,696         | 176           | 66         | 519                       | 3,674                           | 19,639                            | 19,555                         |
|               | Dec-25 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | -                               | -                  | -             | -             | -          | -                         | -                               | -                                 | 3,710                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | -                               | -                  | -             | -             | -          | -                         | -                               | -                                 | 7,960                          |
|               | MWS-26 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 690                             | 117                | 0             | 1,514         | 550        | 12,936                    | 178                             | 15,985                            | 1,805                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 2,223                           | 117                | 0             | 1,954         | 880        | 14,834                    | 4,102                           | 24,110                            | 6,125                          |
|               | Jan-26 | Mallards    | -                           | -      | 997                             | 1,621              | 416           | 484           | 528        | 8,030                     | 0                               | 12,075                            | 8,030                          |
|               |        | Total Ducks | -                           | -      | 3,833                           | 1,804              | 416           | 484           | 528        | 18,477                    | 0                               | 25,542                            | 19,365                         |

Figure 1. Duck abundance estimates in the Mississippi Alluvial Valley (Delta) of Arkansas during the late November (Nov), mid-December (Dec), early-January Midwinter Waterfowl Survey (MWS) and late-January (Jan) aerial waterfowl survey periods, 2009-2026.

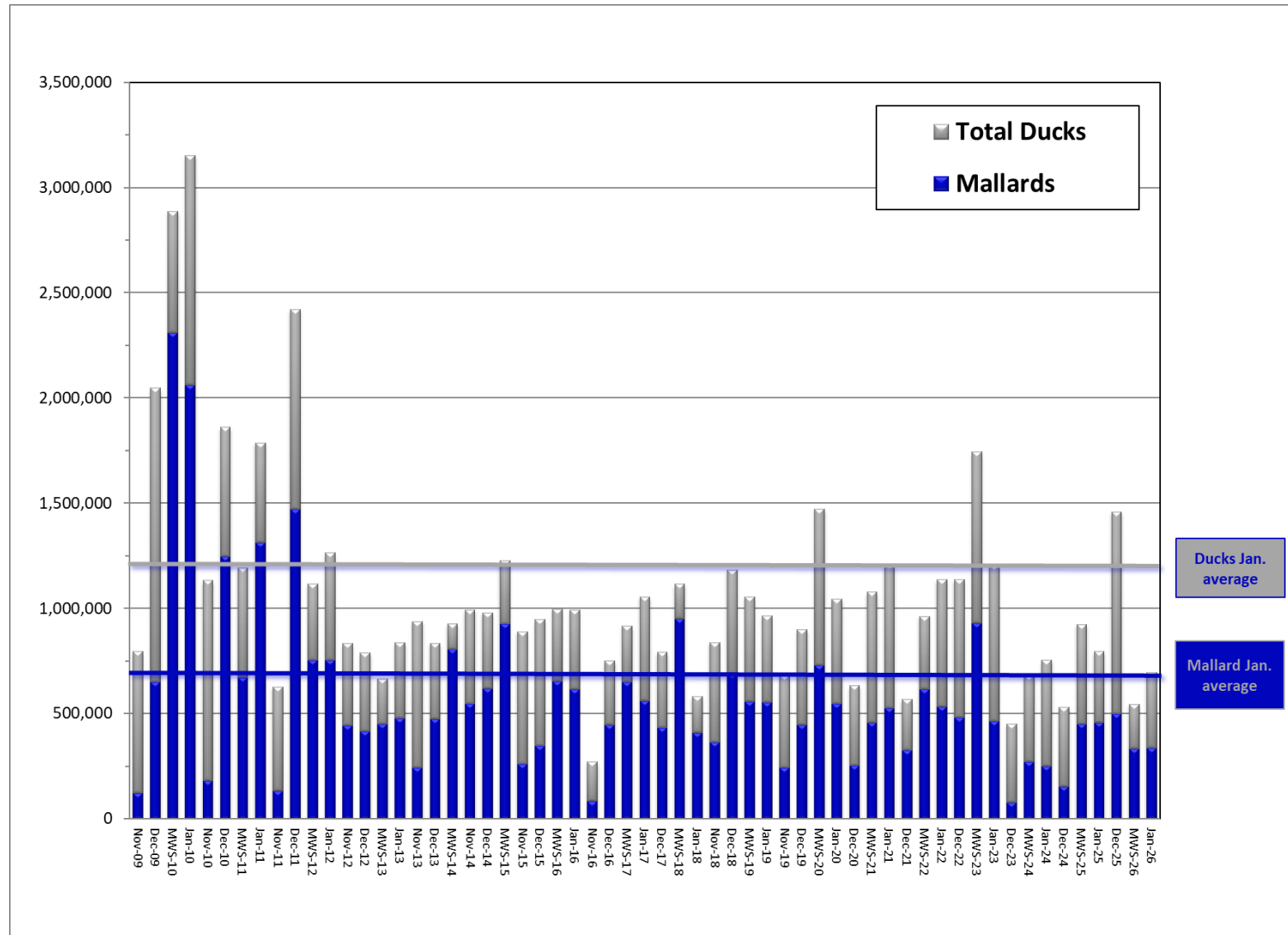


Figure 2. Duck abundance estimates in the Arkansas River valley of Arkansas during the late November (Nov), mid-December (Dec), early-January Midwinter Waterfowl Survey (MWS) and late-January (Jan) aerial waterfowl survey periods, 2009-2026.

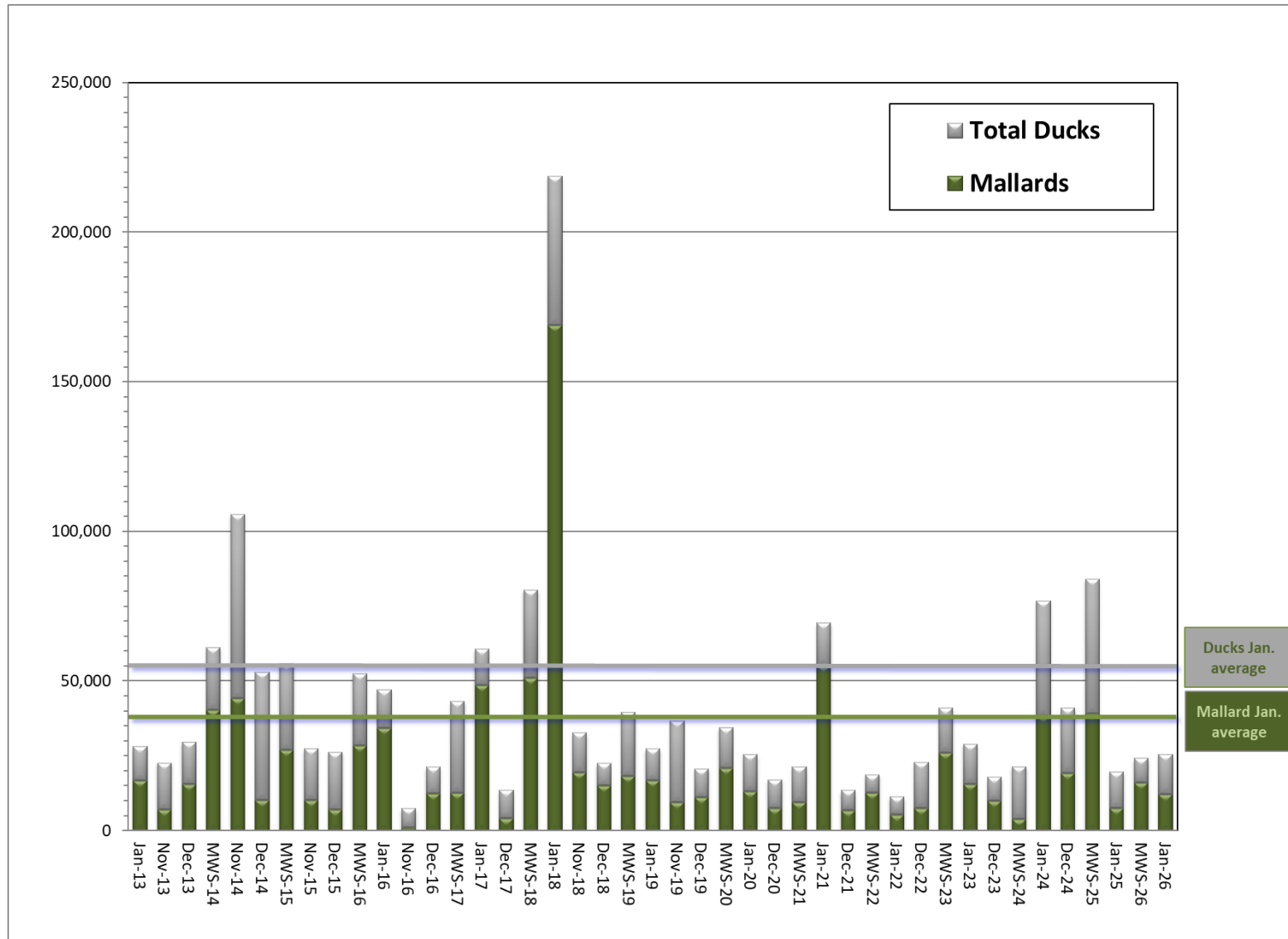


Figure 3. Duck distribution in the Mississippi Alluvial Valley of Arkansas during the late-January 2026 aerial waterfowl survey period.

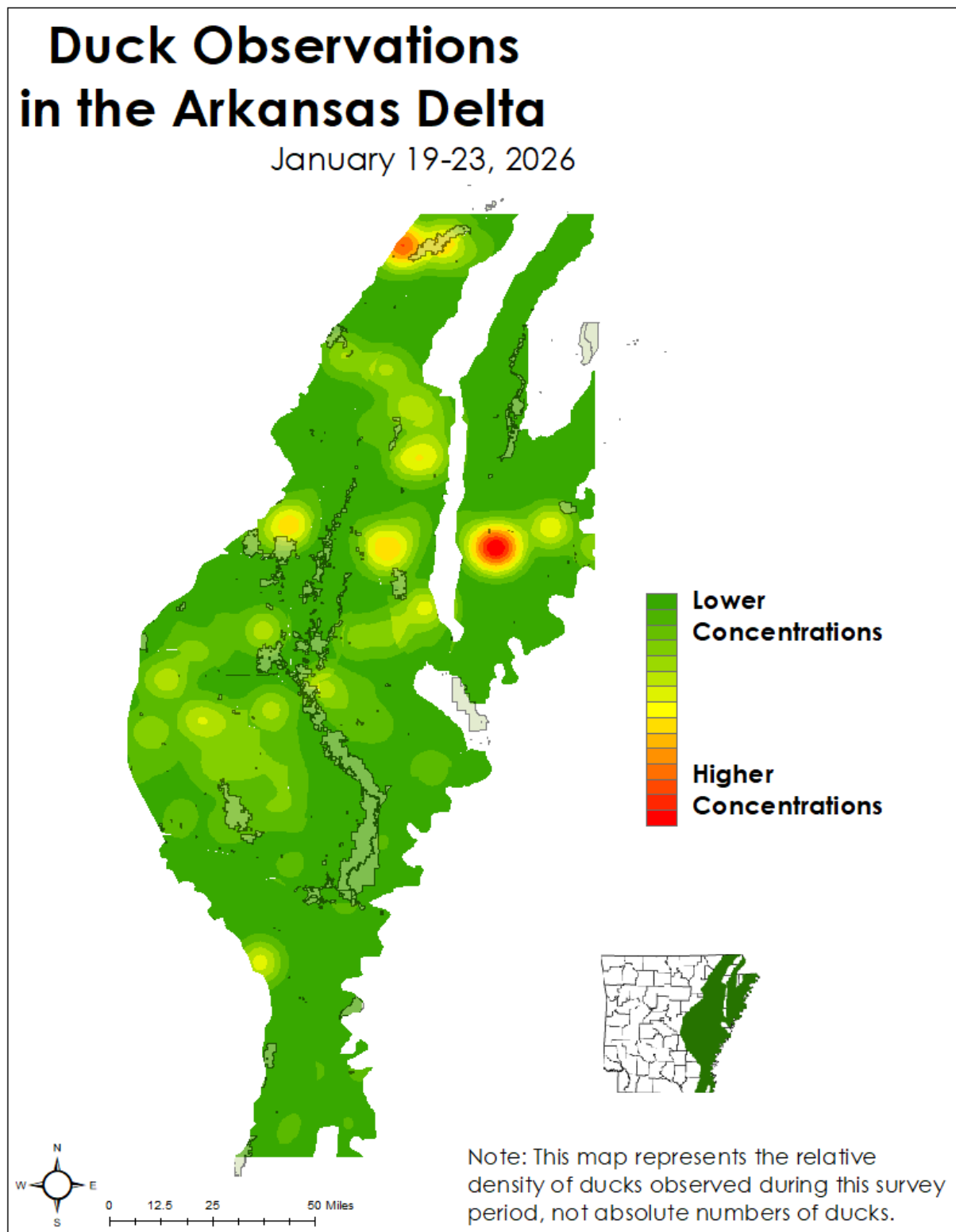




Figure 4. Mallard distribution in the Mississippi Alluvial Valley of Arkansas during the late-January 2026 aerial waterfowl survey period.

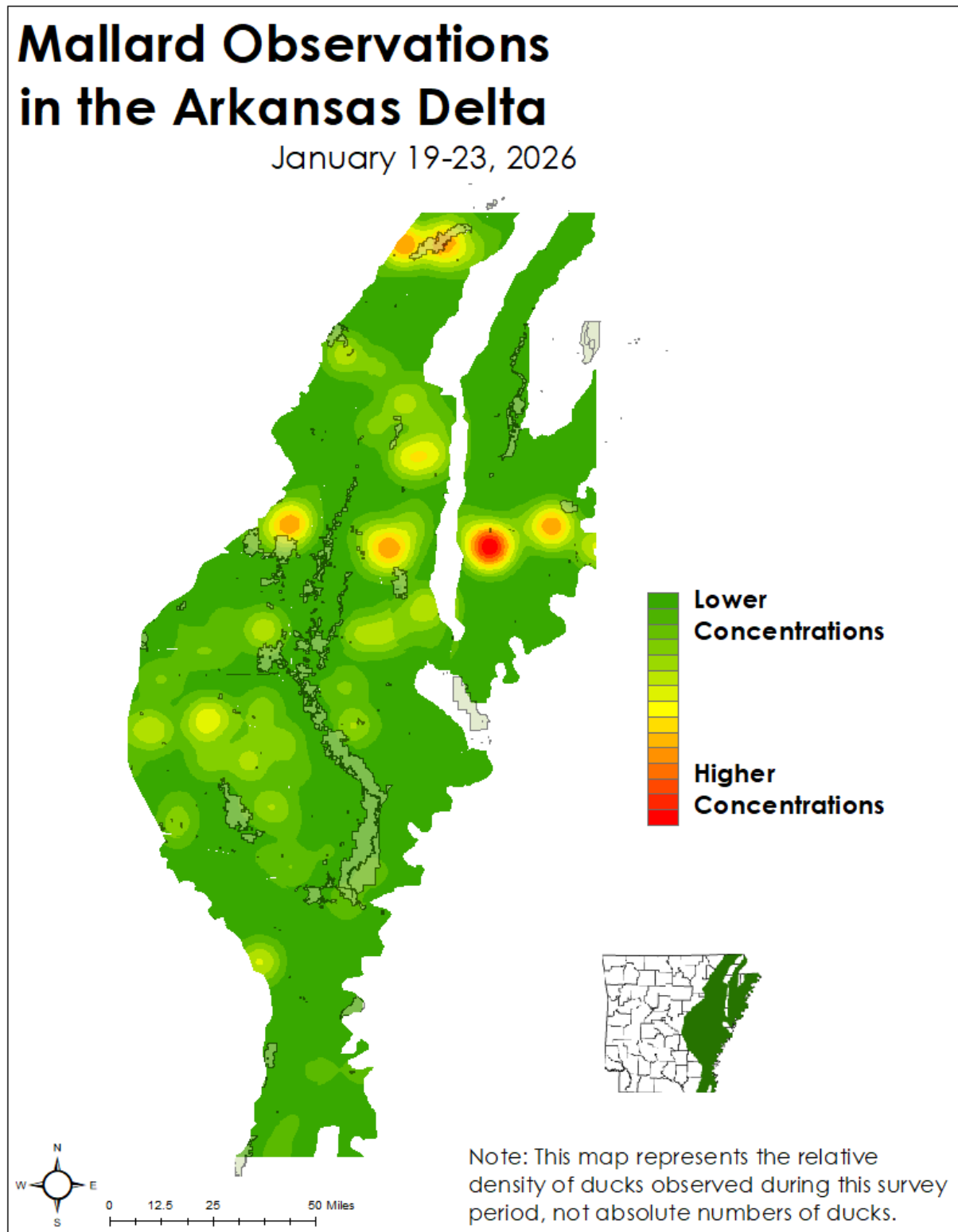


Figure 5. Duck distribution in the Arkansas River Valley (ARV) of Arkansas during the late-January 2026 waterfowl survey period.

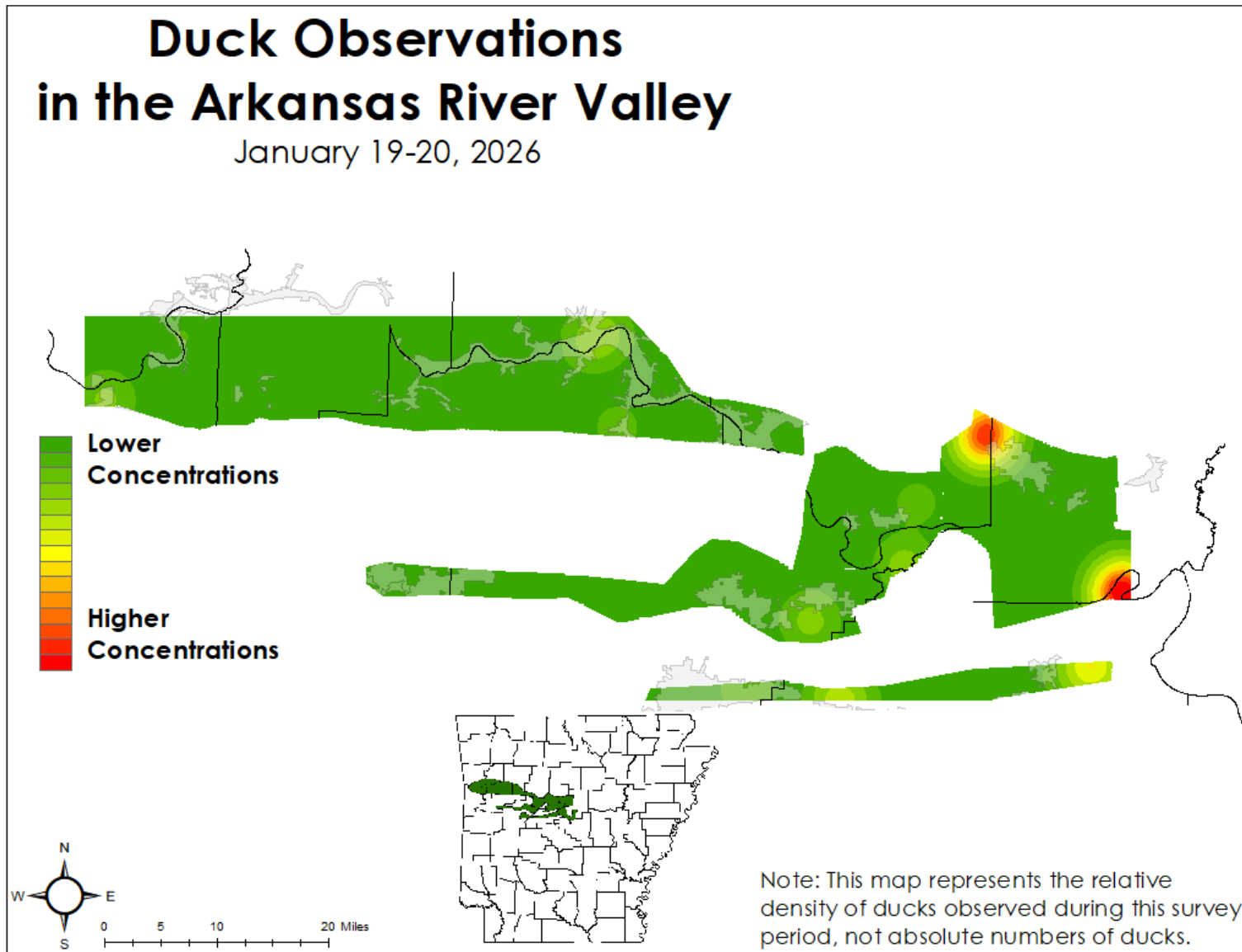


Figure 6. Mallard distribution in the Arkansas River Valley (ARV) of Arkansas during the late-January 2026 waterfowl survey period.

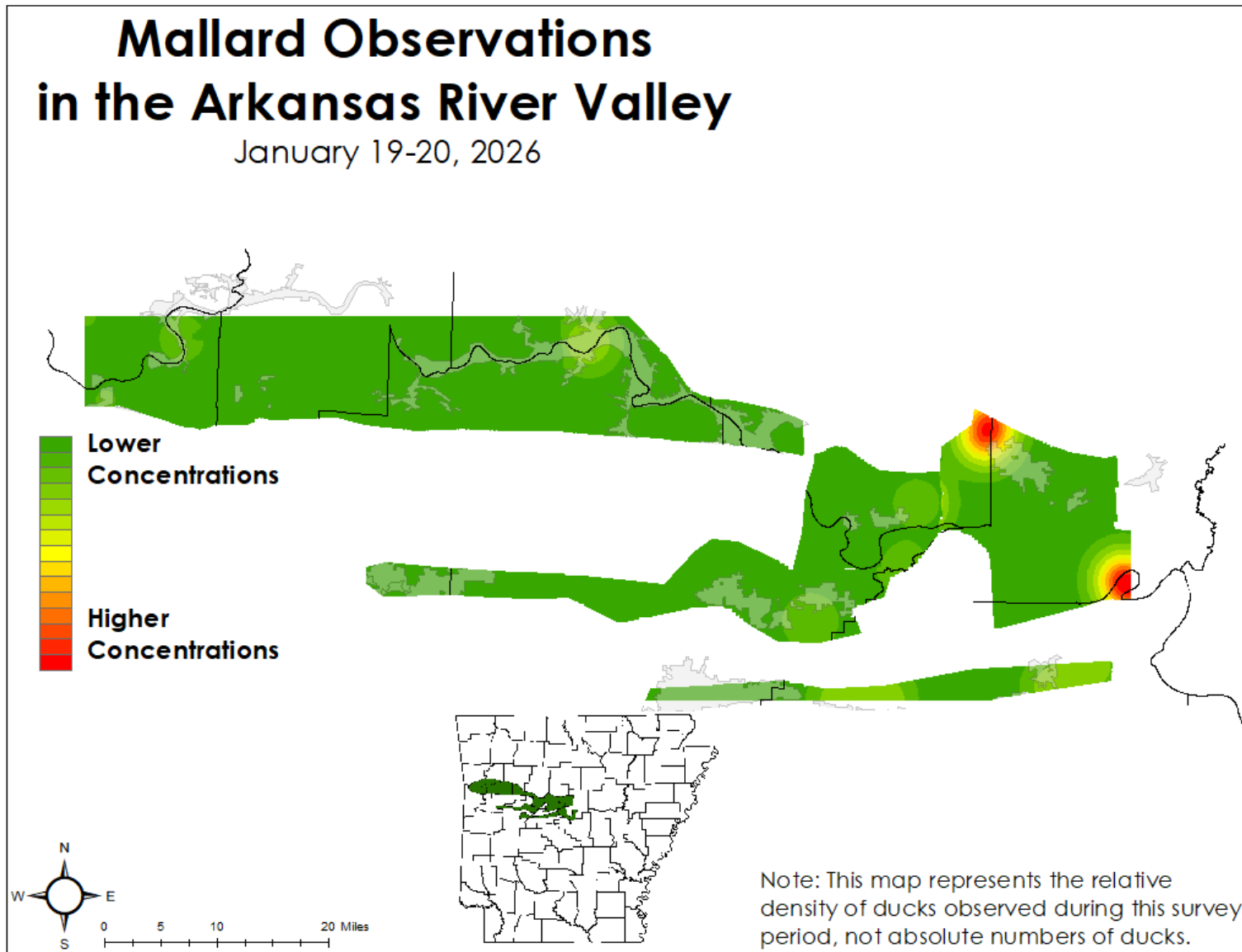


Figure 7. Total precipitation ranks throughout Arkansas during the 2025-26 waterfowl hunting season.

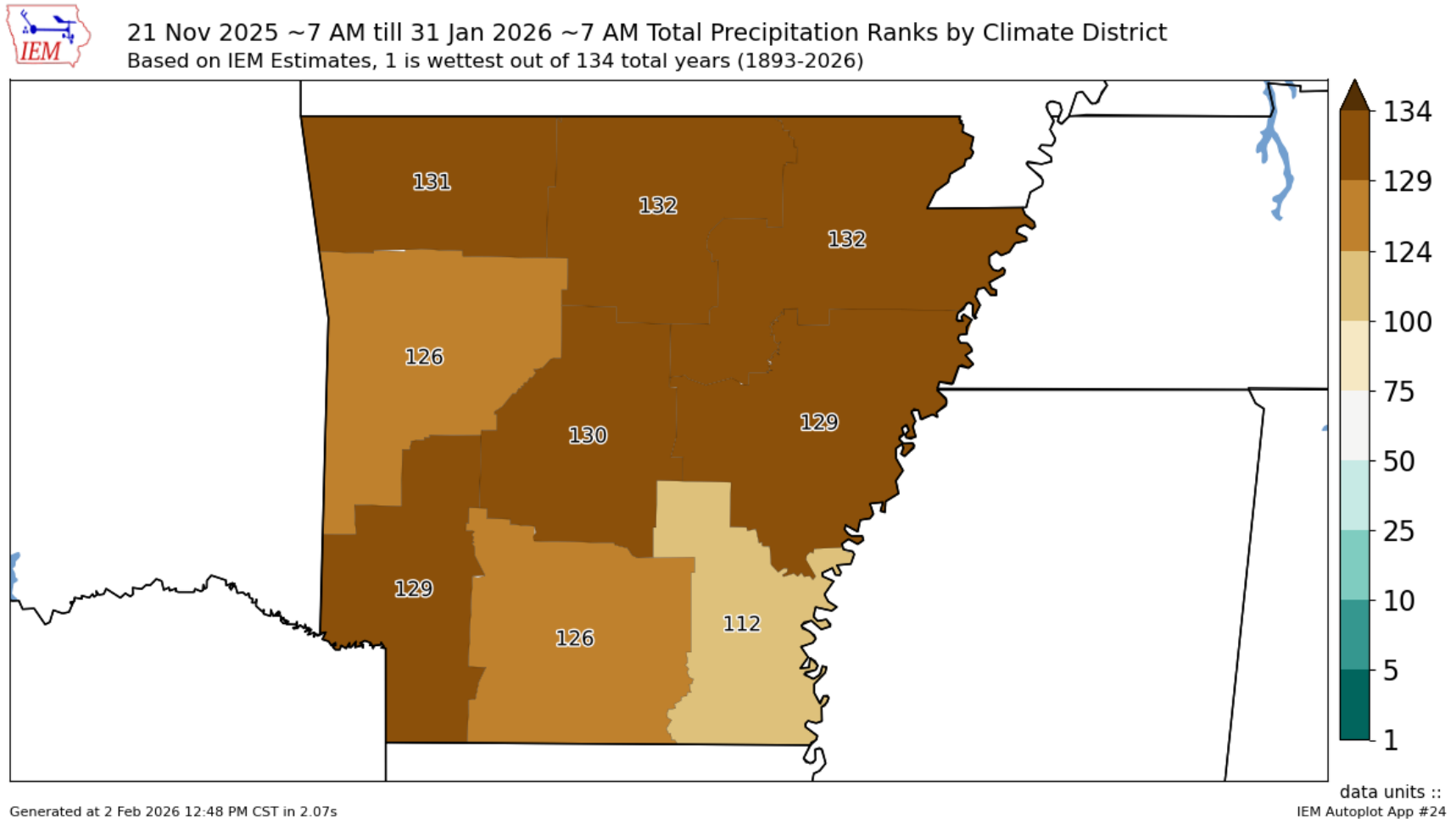
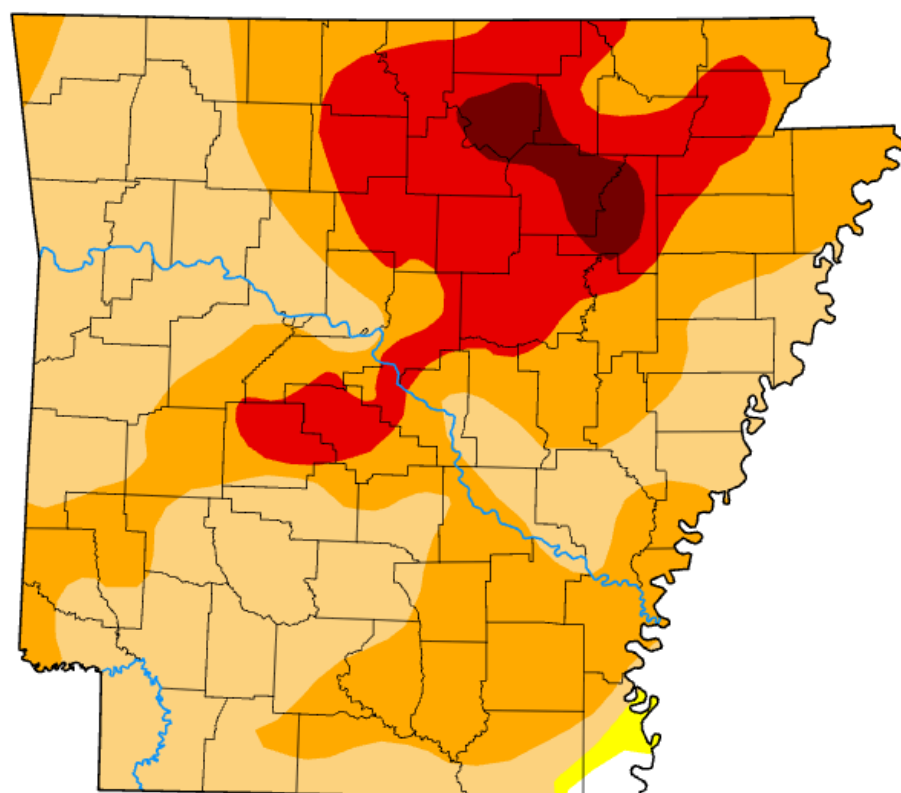


Figure 8. Drought severity throughout Arkansas as of January 27, 2026.



**Map released: Thurs. January 29, 2026**

Data valid: January 27, 2026 at 7 a.m. EST

## Intensity

- None
- D0 (Abnormally Dry)
- D1 (Moderate Drought)
- D2 (Severe Drought)
- D3 (Extreme Drought)
- D4 (Exceptional Drought)
- No Data

## Authors

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## **Survey Design Background**

The Mississippi Alluvial Valley is an area of continental significance for migrating and wintering waterfowl, as outlined in the North American Waterfowl Management Plan, and the single most important region for wintering mallards. Habitats found in western Arkansas, including the Arkansas River Valley and southwest Arkansas, such as the Red River and Sulphur River floodplains, provide additional critical habitat for migrating and wintering waterfowl. Biologists conduct regular waterfowl surveys in these regions by aircraft up to four times each wintering period.

Winter waterfowl surveys, including the Midwinter Waterfowl Survey, have been conducted across much of the United States since 1935. Many different counting techniques have been used, and recently AGFC and partners have conducted surveys in the MAV using stratified random sampling of aerial fixed width (250m) strips, or transects, that have the advantages of extensive coverage (i.e., no area is excluded from the sample), increased accuracy by counting on fixed strips rather than traditional “cruise” surveys only counting waterfowl on large concentration areas, and availability of measures of sampling error.

Beginning in 2011 in the MAV, survey strata – or sampling zones – follow watershed boundaries (Figure 9). Watersheds in this case are simply land areas that are occupied by a drainage system consisting of a portion of a surface stream and all the tributary surface streams feeding it. For example, the Cache River strata includes lands surrounding and tributaries flowing into the Cache River from the Missouri border on the north to the Cache River’s junction with the White River on the south. At the root of this sampling design is the idea that habitat within these zones will share common weather and flooding patterns and, knowing that ducks are keyed in on such patterns, duck distribution will vary among watersheds. This is not a concept foreign to those who follow ducks, particularly duck hunters, as they frequently discuss habitat and duck numbers in terms of conditions in the “Cache River bottoms,” for instance. Systematically conducting aerial waterfowl surveys using this design will allow for more efficient allocation of sampling effort and provide precise estimates of waterfowl abundance in the MAV. Such a design offers an opportunity to track changes in abundance in response to changes in land use, flooding patterns or weather conditions, for example.

Before each survey period, transects to be flown are randomly selected within each strata. Biologists spend many hours in the air flying each of these transects – totaling over 3,500 miles each survey – recording all waterfowl observations using specialized computer software that collects location information in flight. Biologists also collect habitat information for each duck observation to track trends in habitat use. These data can then be used to generate population estimates for each strata and the entire MAV and develop visual representations of duck distribution (i.e., duck density maps).

Figure 9. Aerial waterfowl survey strata in the Mississippi Alluvial Valley (Delta) of Arkansas.

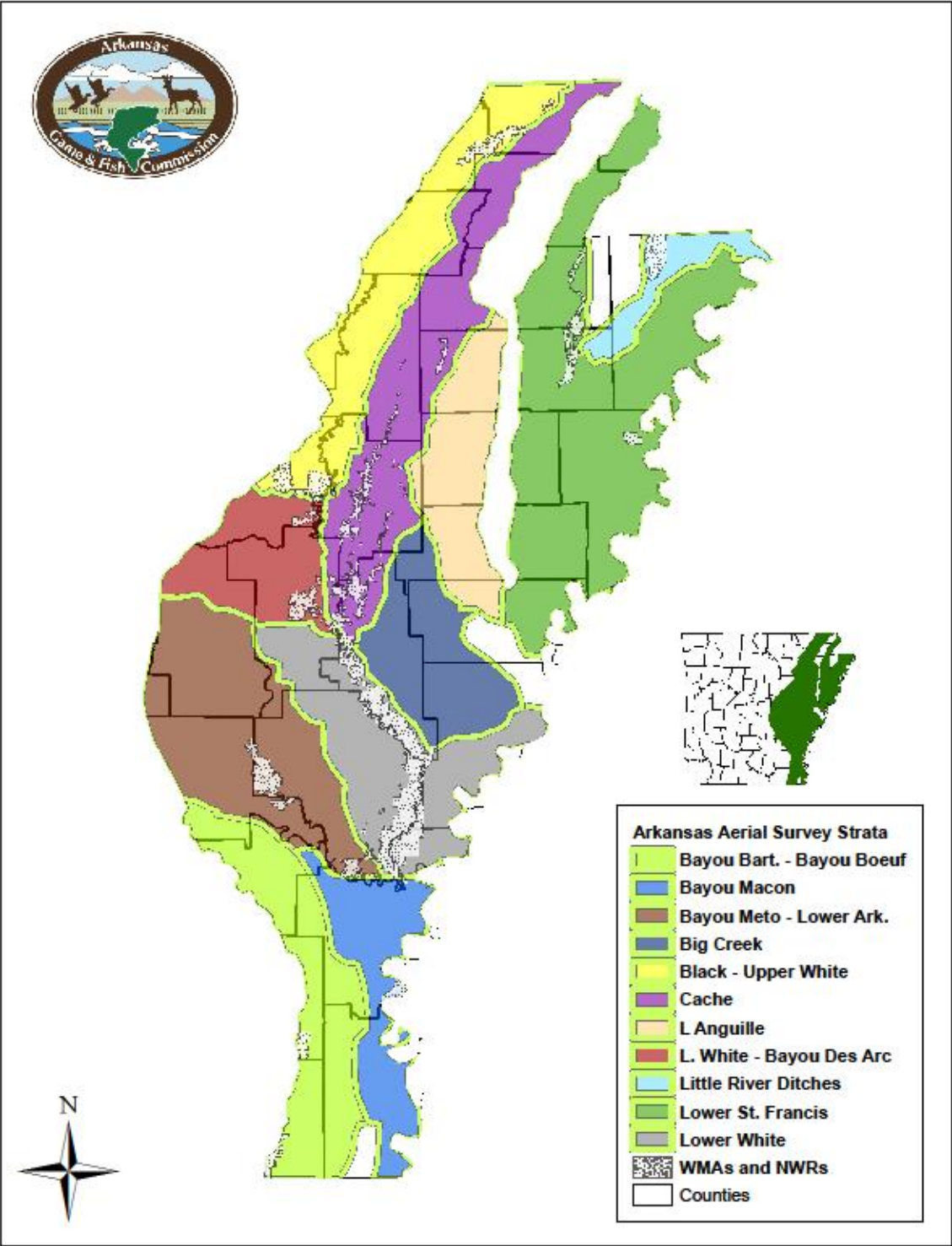


Figure 10. Aerial waterfowl survey strata in the Arkansas River valley (ARV) of western Arkansas.

